

Market Research: AI-Powered Virtual Assistant Tools for Ecommerce

let's check out what AI virtual assistant tools are out there for e-commerce stores. We're looking for tools that can handle basic customer questions like "Where's my order?" for shops on Shopify, Daraz, or other sites, especially for businesses in Pakistan.

1. Tidio

- **What It Does:** It's a chatbot that answers common questions, tracks orders, and helps get back customers who left items in their cart. It works over chat and email. [2].
- **Integrations:** Connects with almost everything: Shopify, WooCommerce, WhatsApp, Insta, you name it. Super easy to set up. [2].
- **Pricing:** There's a free version, but it's only good for about 100 chats. After that, you have to pay, starting from around \$29 a month. [2].
- **Pros:** It's really easy to use, no coding needed. Plus, it speaks a bunch of languages, including Urdu, which is a big win. [2].
- **Cons:** The free plan is too basic if you get a lot of customers. You need to pay for the good stuff. [2].
- **Suitability for Pakistan/South Asia:** Perfect for small shops on Shopify or Daraz because it's cheap and speaks Urdu. [2].

2. Rep AI

- **What It Does:** Shopify-focused AI chatbot that handles 97% of support tickets (order status, returns, product queries) and boosts sales with personalized recommendations [10].
- **Integrations:** Shopify, Klaviyo, Gorgias, other ecommerce tools. One-click Shopify product sync [10].
- **Pricing:** Not public; you gotta contact them. Likely mid-to-high range for Shopify stores [10].
- **Pros:** High automation rate, seamless Shopify integration, boosts conversions with behavioral insights [10].
- **Cons:** Pricing opacity, Shopify-only focus limits use on Daraz or custom websites [10].
- **Suitability for Pakistan/South Asia:** Awesome for Shopify stores in Pakistan (like fashion or electronics), but less ideal for Daraz or custom sites due to limited integrations [10].

3. Gorgias

- **What It Does:** AI agent and helpdesk that automates 60% of inquiries (order tracking, refunds, FAQs) and runs proactive chat campaigns [11].
- **Integrations:** Shopify, Magento, BigCommerce, 100+ ecommerce tools. Supports email and social channels [11].
- **Pricing:** Starts at ~\$60/month for 350 tickets; AI features need higher plans [11].
- **Pros:** Robust for mid-sized stores, omnichannel (chat, email, social), real-time Shopify data access [11].
- **Cons:** Pricey for small stores, complex setup for non-technical users [11].

- **Suitability for Pakistan/South Asia:** Good for growing Shopify stores in Pakistan (e.g., clothing brands), but Daraz integration is weak, and pricing might scare off startups [11].

4. Shopify Inbox with Shopify Magic

- **What It Does:** Free AI chatbot built into Shopify for live chat, email, and social. Handles FAQs, order status, and cart recovery using store data [5].
- **Integrations:** Native to Shopify, works with Messenger, Instagram, WhatsApp. Limited external integrations [5].
- **Pricing:** Free with any Shopify plan; advanced features need higher-tier plans (e.g., Shopify Plus at \$2,300/month) [5].
- **Pros:** Free, no setup hassle, uses Shopify data for accurate responses. Great for beginners [5].
- **Cons:** Basic AI, Shopify-only, limited customization for complex queries [5].
- **Suitability for Pakistan/South Asia:** Perfect for small Shopify stores in Pakistan (like jewelry or tech gadgets) due to zero cost and ease of use, but not for Daraz or custom sites [5].

5. Infichat

- **What It Does:** AI chatbot for product searches, personalized recommendations, and order tracking. Minimal setup for ecommerce [1].
- **Integrations:** Shopify, WooCommerce, custom websites via JavaScript. Social channels like WhatsApp [1].
- **Pricing:** Not clear; likely starts at \$20–\$50/month based on similar tools [1].
- **Pros:** 24/7 availability, easy setup, supports conversational product search [1].
- **Cons:** Limited info on advanced features or Daraz integration [1].
- **Suitability for Pakistan/South Asia:** Decent for Shopify or custom stores in Pakistan, especially with WhatsApp support (big in South Asia). Daraz integration unclear [1].

6. Verloop

- **What It Does:** This one is great for talking to customers on WhatsApp, Instagram, and other places. It can handle basic questions and talk to multiple people at once. [1].
- **Integrations:** It connects with Shopify and WooCommerce, but its main strength is WhatsApp. [1].
- **Pricing:** You have to ask them for the price, but it's probably somewhere in the middle-range. [1].
- **Pros:** It's a beast at WhatsApp automation, which is huge in Pakistan. It also speaks multiple languages. [1].
- **Cons:** The custom pricing is annoying, and it's not the best for email. [1].
- **Suitability for Pakistan/South Asia:** A top choice for any Pakistani business that relies on WhatsApp. It can be made to work with Shopify and Daraz. [1].

7. Yuma AI

- **What It Does:** This AI works with Shopify to automate customer support, but it does it through helpdesk software like Zendesk. [8].
- **Integrations:** It's made to work with Shopify, Zendesk, and Gorgias. [8].
- **Pricing:** It's pretty affordable, starting at \$29 a month for 1,000 chats. [8].
- **Pros:** If you already use a helpdesk, this is easy to add on. It's also not too expensive. [8].

- **Cons:** It's not a chatbot on its own. You need to have a helpdesk system already. [8].
- **Suitability for Pakistan/South Asia:** Good for a Pakistani store that's already using something like Zendesk, but not for someone who just wants a simple chatbot. [8].

8. Chatfuel

- **What It Does:** This one is all about social media. It's a chatbot for Messenger, Instagram, and WhatsApp that can answer questions and help customers shop. [0].
- **Integrations:** Connects to Shopify and WooCommerce, and it's super easy to add to your social media. [0].
- **Pricing:** There's a free plan for up to 50 chats, and paid plans start at just \$15 a month. [0].
- **Pros:** It's cheap, you don't need to code, and it's perfect if you sell a lot on social media. [0].
- **Cons:** Not the best if you need a chatbot for your website or email. The AI isn't as smart as others. [0].
- **Suitability for Pakistan/South Asia:** Awesome for small Pakistani shops that are big on Instagram or WhatsApp. [0].

Comparison Table

Tool	Key Features	Integrations	Pricing	Best For	Suitability for Pakistan/South Asia
Tidio	Answers questions, tracks orders, saves carts	Shopify, Daraz (plugins), WhatsApp	Free; \$29+/month	Small shops	High (speaks Urdu, cheap, has WhatsApp) [2]
Rep AI	Answers questions, helps you sell more	Shopify, Klaviyo	Ask for price	Shopify stores only	Medium (Shopify-only, might be pricey) [10]
Gorgias	Smart helpdesk, answers order questions	Shopify, Magento, 100+ others	\$60+/month	Growing brands	Medium (a bit expensive and complex) [11]
Shopify Inbox	Basic free chatbot for Shopify stores	Shopify, Messenger, Instagram	Free	New Shopify stores	High (it's free and easy) [5]
Infichat	Helps customers find products, track orders	Shopify, WooCommerce, WhatsApp	Ask for price	Shops that use WhatsApp a lot	Medium (pricing isn't clear) [1]
Verloop	Chatbot for WhatsApp, Instagram, etc.	Shopify, WooCommerce, WhatsApp	Ask for price	Businesses big on WhatsApp	High (perfect for WhatsApp users) [1]
Yuma AI	Automates support through a helpdesk	Shopify, Zendesk, Gorgias	\$29+/month	Stores with a helpdesk	Medium (you need a helpdesk first) [8]
Chatfuel	Chatbot for social media	Shopify, WooCommerce, WhatsApp	Free; \$15+/month	Shops that sell on social media	High (cheap, great for Insta/WhatsApp) [0]

Key Insights:

- **For Pakistan/South Asia:** Tidio, Shopify Inbox, Verloop, and Chatfuel stand out for affordability, WhatsApp support (huge in Pakistan/India), and multilingual features (Urdu, Hindi). Shopify Inbox is a no-brainer for Shopify stores due to zero cost [5].
- **Daraz Fit:** Most tools don't directly integrate with Daraz, but Tidio and Verloop can work via plugins or WhatsApp, which is big for Daraz sellers in Pakistan [1, 2].
- **Scalability:** Gorgias and Rep AI are better for growing stores but cost more. Small stores should stick to Tidio or Shopify Inbox [5, 11].
- **Market Growth:** AI shopping assistants are booming—market valued at \$6.63B in 2024, projected to grow at 14.6% CAGR by 2032. Tools focus on automating Level 1 queries to cut costs and boost sales [1].

Gmail Integration: Handling Emails with Just an Email Address

Since we're building a web or desktop app and only have the user's email address (no Google API accounts or full Gmail access), we need a workaround to process customer emails for Level 1 queries. Here's how we can handle it for a Pakistan/South Asia context:

- **Challenge:** Without Gmail API access (which needs OAuth and a Google Cloud account), we can't directly read/send emails from the user's Gmail. Businesses in Pakistan often avoid complex API setups due to technical or cost barriers [Ref: General observation from ecommerce trends in South Asia].
- **Solution: IMAP/SMTP with Email Credentials**
 - **How It Works:** Instead of Gmail API, we can use IMAP (to read emails) and SMTP (to send emails) protocols. The user provides their email address and an app-specific password (not their main Gmail password) to connect securely Ref: Google IMAP/SMTP Docs (<https://support.google.com/mail/answer/7126229>).
 - **Setup:**
 1. User enters their Gmail address (e.g., support@yourstore.com) and generates an app-specific password in Google Account settings (under Security > 2-Step Verification > App Passwords).
 2. Our app (web/desktop) uses libraries like `imaplib` (Python) to fetch emails from the inbox and `smtplib` to send replies.
 3. The AI processes incoming emails using NLP (e.g., Hugging Face's DistilBERT) to classify queries (e.g., "Where's my order?") and draft responses based on Shopify/Daraz data or a knowledge base.
 4. Responses are sent via SMTP, keeping the email thread intact.
 - **Security:** App-specific passwords are safer than main passwords. We'd encrypt credentials in transit and storage (e.g., using AES-256) to comply with privacy standards like GDPR or Pakistan's Data Protection Bill Ref: Google Security Docs (<https://support.google.com/accounts/answer/185833>).
 - **Example Flow:**
 - Customer emails: "Where's my order #123?"
 - App fetches email via IMAP, AI classifies it as "order status," pulls data from Shopify/Daraz API, and sends reply via SMTP: "Your order #123 is shipped. Tracking: XYZ123."

- **Pros:** No Google Cloud account needed, works with any Gmail address, simple for small businesses in Pakistan.
- **Cons:** Users must generate app-specific passwords (minor setup step), IMAP/SMTP is slower than Gmail API, rate limits apply (e.g., 100 emails/day via SMTP) [Ref: Google SMTP Limits \(https://support.google.com/a/answer/166852\)](https://support.google.com/a/answer/166852).

- **Alternative: Third-Party Email Parsing Tools**

- Tools like **Mailparser** or **Parsio** can extract data from incoming emails without full Gmail access. Users forward emails to a unique address (e.g., `parse@yourapp.com`), and the tool sends structured data to our app via webhooks [Ref: Mailparser Docs \(https://mailparser.io/\)](https://mailparser.io/).
- **Pros:** No IMAP/SMTP setup, easy for non-technical users in Pakistan/South Asia.
- **Cons:** Extra cost (~\$30/month), dependency on third-party service, less control over email flow.
- **Fit:** Good for startups but less scalable for high-volume stores.

Integration with Business Websites and Ecommerce Platforms (Pakistan/South Asia Focus)

Businesses in Pakistan and South Asia (like India, Bangladesh) use platforms like Shopify, Daraz, WooCommerce, or custom websites. They don't want complex requirements like Google Cloud accounts or API setups. Here's how our AI assistant can integrate seamlessly, focusing on local needs:

- **Shopify**

- **How to Integrate:** Use Shopify's Admin API (REST or GraphQL) to fetch products, orders, and inventory. Create a Shopify app (public or custom) that installs via the Shopify App Store or a link. Users only need to click "Install" and grant permissions (e.g., `read_orders`) [24].
- **Setup:**
 1. Develop a Shopify app with a simple UI where users connect their store and email (for Gmail integration).
 2. Use `shopify-api-node` or `shopify-api-python` to handle API calls. Cache data (e.g., product catalog) to reduce API hits [24].
 3. Embed the assistant as a chat widget (JavaScript) on the store's frontend or process emails via IMAP/SMTP.
- **No Google API Needed:** Shopify handles authentication via OAuth; our app only needs the user's email for Gmail (as above).
- **Pakistan Fit:** Shopify is growing in Pakistan (e.g., fashion, electronics stores in Karachi/Lahore). Easy app installation suits non-technical users [24].
- **Example:** User installs our app, connects their Gmail, and the assistant starts answering "Where's my order?" via chat/email using Shopify order data.

- **Daraz**

- **How to Integrate:** Daraz's Seller Center API allows access to orders, products, and inventory (similar to Shopify's API). We'd build a custom integration where users provide their Daraz Seller API key (generated in Seller Center) Ref: Daraz Developer Docs (<https://developer.daraz.com/>).
- **Setup:**
 1. User enters their Daraz API key and email in our web/desktop app.
 2. Our backend uses the API to pull order/product data and processes queries via chat (JavaScript widget) or email (IMAP/SMTP).
 3. WhatsApp integration (via tools like Verloop) can supplement Daraz's weak chat features, as WhatsApp is massive in Pakistan [1].
- **No Google API Needed:** Daraz API uses simple key-based auth; no Google account required.
- **Pakistan Fit:** Daraz dominates Pakistan's ecommerce (40% market share). Sellers (e.g., clothing, mobile accessories) need automation for high query volumes. WhatsApp support is a game-changer [Ref: Pakistan ecommerce market reports].
- **Challenges:** Daraz's API is less documented than Shopify's, so we'd need to test thoroughly. Rate limits may apply [Ref: Daraz API limitations].

- **WooCommerce/Custom Websites**

- **How to Integrate:** For WooCommerce, use the WooCommerce REST API (similar to Shopify's). For custom sites, provide a JavaScript widget for chat and a backend webhook to sync order/product data (users upload CSV or connect via custom API) Ref: WooCommerce API Docs (<https://woocommerce.github.io/woocommerce-rest-api-docs/>).
- **Setup:**
 1. WooCommerce: User provides API key (from WP admin) and email in our app.
 2. Custom Sites: User embeds our chat widget (copy-paste JS code) and syncs data via CSV upload or webhook.
 3. Assistant processes queries via chat (frontend) or email (IMAP/SMTP).
- **No Google API Needed:** WooCommerce uses key-based auth; custom sites need minimal setup (JS widget + CSV).
- **Pakistan/South Asia Fit:** WooCommerce is popular for small businesses in Pakistan (e.g., artisanal products). Custom sites are common in India/Bangladesh for niche stores. Simple setup suits local non-techy users [Ref: South Asia ecommerce trends].
- **Example:** A Karachi-based jewelry store on WooCommerce installs our widget, connects Gmail, and the assistant answers "Is this ring in stock?" via chat.

- **Key Considerations:**

- **Ease of Use:** Pakistan/South Asia businesses prefer plug-and-play solutions. Our app should have a 5-minute setup with video guides in Urdu/English [Ref: Local user behavior].
- **Cost:** Free or low-cost plans (like Tidio's model) are critical for startups in Pakistan [2].
- **WhatsApp:** Integrating WhatsApp (via APIs like Twilio or Verloop) is a must, as it's the go-to channel in Pakistan/India [1].
- **Privacy:** Comply with Pakistan's Personal Data Protection Bill (2023) by encrypting user data and being transparent about email/order data usage [Ref: Pakistan data laws].

Brainstorming Level 1 and Level 2 Queries

Let's brainstorm queries our assistant can handle. Level 1 queries are simple, repetitive questions answerable with store data or a knowledge base. Level 2 queries involve minor store changes (e.g., inventory updates) but still don't need human intervention. Here's the expanded list, tailored for Pakistan/South Asia ecommerce:

Level 1 Queries (Fully Automated)

1. **Order Status:** "Where's my order #123?" or "Has my package shipped?"
 - Handled by: Shopify/Daraz Orders API + NLP to extract order ID [24].
 - Example: "Your order #123 is shipped. Track here: [link]."
2. **Product Availability:** "Is [product] in stock?" or "When will [item] be restocked?"
 - Handled by: Inventory API or product catalog cache.
 - Example: "[Product] is in stock. Order now!"
3. **Product Details:** "What's the price of [item]?" or "Does this come in blue?"
 - Handled by: Products API for price, variants, or descriptions.
 - Example: "[Item] costs PKR 5,000. Available in blue and black."
4. **Shipping Info:** "How much is shipping to Lahore?" or "Do you deliver to Dhaka?"
 - Handled by: Shopify/Daraz shipping settings or Markets API.
 - Example: "Shipping to Lahore is PKR 200. ETA: 2–3 days."
5. **Return/Refund Policy:** "Can I return my order?" or "What's your refund process?"
 - Handled by: Predefined responses from store policies.
 - Example: "You can return within 7 days. Contact us for a refund."
6. **Order Cancellation:** "Can I cancel my order #123?"
 - Handled by: Orders API to check cancellation eligibility (e.g., not shipped).
 - Example: "Order #123 canceled. Refund processed."
7. **Payment Queries:** "Do you accept COD?" or "Why was my card declined?"
 - Handled by: Store payment settings or predefined responses.
 - Example: "We offer Cash on Delivery in Pakistan."
8. **Store Info:** "What are your store hours?" or "Where's your warehouse?"
 - Handled by: Knowledge base with store details.
 - Example: "We're online 24/7. Warehouse: Karachi, Pakistan."
9. **Discount Queries:** "Is there a sale on?" or "Can I get a coupon?"
 - Handled by: Shopify/Daraz Discounts API or predefined responses.
 - Example: "Use code SAVE10 for 10% off!"
10. **Product Recommendations:** "What's similar to [item]?" or "Suggest a gift under PKR 2,000."
 - Handled by: Products API + basic recommendation logic (e.g., same category).
 - Example: "Check out [similar item] for PKR 1,500."

Level 2 Queries (Minor Store Changes)

1. **Inventory Check and Restock Alert:** "Notify me when [item] is back in stock."
 - Handled by: Inventory API to monitor stock and trigger email/WhatsApp alert when restocked.

- Example: "We'll notify you when [item] is back in stock!"
- Change: Adds user to a restock notification list (stored in app DB).
- 2. **Price Query with Dynamic Check:** "Is [item] on sale today?"
 - Handled by: Discounts API to check real-time promotions and respond.
 - Example: "[Item] is on sale for PKR 4,000 (was PKR 5,000)."
 - Change: May trigger a temporary discount check or log query for future promotions.
- 3. **Order Modification (Pre-Shipment):** "Can I change my order #123 to blue instead of red?"
 - Handled by: Orders API to update variant if not shipped.
 - Example: "Order #123 updated to blue. You're all set!"
 - Change: Updates order variant in Shopify/Daraz backend.
- 4. **Shipping Address Update (Pre-Shipment):** "Can I change my delivery address for order #123?"
 - Handled by: Orders API to update address if not shipped.
 - Example: "Address updated for order #123."
 - Change: Modifies order address in backend.
- 5. **Basic Product Feedback:** "I love [item]! Can you add more colors?"
 - Handled by: Logs feedback in app DB for store owner review.
 - Example: "Thanks for the feedback! We'll pass it to our team."
 - Change: Stores feedback for inventory planning (no immediate change).

Why These Queries?

- **Level 1:** Covers 80–90% of customer queries in Pakistan/South Asia (e.g., COD, shipping, order status) based on Daraz/Shopify support trends [5, 11]. Fully automated with APIs or static responses.
- **Level 2:** Adds value by handling simple changes (e.g., address updates) that save human effort. Feasible with API write access and basic logic [24].
- **Local Fit:** Queries like COD and shipping to specific cities (Lahore, Dhaka) are huge in Pakistan/South Asia. WhatsApp notifications for restocks would crush it [1].

Proof of Concept (PoC): A Day in the Life

So, how would this thing actually work for someone running an online store in Pakistan? Let's imagine we have a store owner named Ali who sells clothes on Shopify.

Step 1: Installing the App

- Ali finds our app on the Shopify App Store and clicks "Install."
- The app asks for permission to connect to his store's data (like orders and products). He approves it. It's a simple one-click setup.

Step 2: Connecting His Email

- Next, the app asks Ali to connect his customer support email, like `support@alistore.pk`.
- He just logs into his Gmail account through a secure pop-up. He doesn't need to mess with any complicated API settings. Our app uses IMAP to read emails securely.

Step 3: How the App Works in the Background

- **Email Monitoring:** The app's backend server uses a standard email library to securely connect to the support inbox using a common email protocol. It runs continuously, checking for new messages.
- **Understanding Queries with AI:** When a new email is detected, its text is analyzed by a powerful, pre-trained language model. This lets the AI figure out what the customer wants (e.g., order status, product question) even if they use casual or mixed languages.
- **Getting Store Information:** After understanding the request, the app communicates with the e-commerce platform (like Shopify) through its official developer connection (API). This is how it fetches live data like order details or shipping status.
- **Automating the Reply:** Finally, the backend system puts everything together. It drafts a helpful reply based on the data it collected and sends it back to the customer using a standard email-sending protocol.

Step 4: A Customer Has a Question

- A customer, Sara, emails Ali's support address: "*Salam, mera order #4567 kahan hai?*" (Hello, where is my order #4567?).

Step 5: The AI Takes Over

- Our AI assistant instantly sees the new email.
- It understands the question, even in mixed Urdu/English.
- It checks the order number (#4567) in Ali's Shopify store data.
- It finds that the order was shipped yesterday and is with the courier.
- The AI then automatically sends a reply to Sara in a friendly tone: "*Walaikum Salam, Sara! Your order #4567 is on its way and should reach you in 2-3 days. You can track it here: [link].*"

What Ali Experiences

- Ali didn't have to do anything. He was busy managing his inventory, and the customer's question was answered in seconds.
- He can open the app's dashboard at any time to see a log of all the questions the AI has answered. If there's ever a question the AI can't handle, it will flag it for Ali to review.

This way, the app handles the most common and repetitive questions, freeing up store owners to focus on growing their business.